

ORCHESTRATING RESILIENCE

A Bi-Coastal Living Learning Lab

Atlanta | Los Angeles | San Francisco | San Diego

UNPRECEDENTED EVENT CONCENTRATION: 2026-2029

FIFA World Cup 2026 • Super Bowl LX (2026) • Super Bowl LXI (2027)
LA 2028 Olympics • Super Bowl 2029 Atlanta

Comprehensive Research Framework

Version 2.0

NOVATELabs

Research Center for Innovation Equity and Responsible Design

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Executive Summary

The United States is about to experience the greatest concentration of major sporting events in its history—occurring simultaneously with accelerating climate disasters, deepening socioeconomic divides, and rapid technology transformation. Between 2026 and 2029, California and Georgia will collectively host FIFA World Cup matches, three Super Bowls, and the Summer Olympics—while both states face wildfires, hurricanes, housing crises, and infrastructure strain.

This convergence creates an unprecedented research opportunity: to understand how major events can serve as catalysts for building community resilience, developing innovation workforce pipelines, and advancing responsible technology practices—rather than extracting resources from already-stressed communities.

Orchestrating Resilience v2.0 establishes a **Bi-Coastal Living Learning Lab** spanning Atlanta and California's major event corridors. This expanded framework examines how sports and entertainment—when orchestrated with intention, equity, and community partnership—can bridge ecosystems and create dimensional impact across emergency preparedness, critical infrastructure, workforce development, and community innovation.

ATLANTA HUB FIFA World Cup 2026 Super Bowl 2029 <i>Hurricane/severe weather corridor</i>	CALIFORNIA HUB FIFA World Cup 2026 (3 cities) Super Bowls 2026 & 2027 LA 2028 Olympics <i>Wildfire/earthquake/drought zone</i>
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Why This Matters Now

- **Compounding Crises:** Major events stress systems already strained by climate disasters, housing shortages, and economic inequality
- **Technology Acceleration:** AI, surveillance, and predictive systems are being deployed in event environments without adequate governance
- **Workforce Transformation:** Events create temporary employment that rarely leads to sustainable careers for host community residents
- **Community Displacement:** Event-driven development displaces the very communities that give host cities their cultural identity
- **Once-in-Generation Opportunity:** This concentration of events will not recur—the research window is now

Part I: The Bi-Coastal Context

1.1 California: Convergence of Events and Existential Challenges

California faces a unique convergence: the nation's highest concentration of major sporting events occurring in a state experiencing accelerating climate disasters, chronic housing crisis, and profound socioeconomic inequality. This creates both extraordinary risk and unprecedented opportunity.

Major Events Timeline

Year	Event	Location & Notes
2026	Super Bowl LX	Levi's Stadium, Santa Clara (San Francisco Bay Area)
2026	FIFA World Cup	Los Angeles (SoFi), San Francisco (Levi's), San Diego (potential)
2027	Super Bowl LXI	SoFi Stadium, Inglewood (Los Angeles)
2028	Summer Olympics	Los Angeles—multiple venues across Southern California

Compounding Challenges

Climate & Natural Disasters:

- **Wildfires:** California's fire season now year-round; 2025 LA fires displaced 100,000+ residents
- **Earthquakes:** Major seismic events overdue on Hayward and San Andreas faults
- **Drought:** Chronic water scarcity affecting agriculture, urban systems, and fire risk
- **Extreme Heat:** Record temperatures creating public health emergencies, particularly for outdoor events
- **Flooding:** Atmospheric rivers causing catastrophic flooding (2023 events caused \$30B+ damage)

Socioeconomic Challenges:

- **Housing Crisis:** Median home price \$800K+; 170,000+ experiencing homelessness statewide
- **Income Inequality:** Highest Gini coefficient in nation; tech wealth alongside deep poverty
- **Immigration:** Border dynamics, immigrant workforce essential to event operations
- **Infrastructure Strain:** Aging power grid, water systems, and transportation under climate stress

1.2 Atlanta: Southern Hub with Distinct Challenges

Atlanta anchors the southeastern hub of the research program, offering distinct conditions that complement California research while enabling comparative analysis across regional contexts.

Major Events Timeline

Year	Event	Location & Notes
2026	FIFA World Cup	Mercedes-Benz Stadium—multiple matches
2029	Super Bowl	Mercedes-Benz Stadium—Atlanta's 4th Super Bowl

Compounding Challenges

Climate & Natural Disasters:

- **Hurricanes:** Increasing inland impacts from Atlantic storms; 2024 Helene devastated region
- **Severe Weather:** Tornado alley expansion; severe thunderstorms threaten outdoor events
- **Extreme Heat:** Urban heat island effect; dangerous conditions for outdoor workers and attendees
- **Flooding:** Aging stormwater infrastructure; flash flooding in urban areas

Socioeconomic Challenges:

- **Gentrification:** Rapid displacement of historically Black neighborhoods
- **Transportation Equity:** Car-dependent infrastructure limits access for low-income residents
- **Wealth Gap:** Among highest income inequality in major US metros
- **Infrastructure Age:** Water system failures; aging roads and transit

1.3 Comparative Research Value

The bi-coastal design enables research questions that single-site studies cannot address:

- How do different natural disaster profiles (wildfire/earthquake vs. hurricane/tornado) shape emergency preparedness for major events?
- What regional differences exist in community resilience strategies and workforce pathways?
- How do state policy environments (California vs. Georgia) affect responsible technology deployment?
- What lessons transfer across regions, and what requires local adaptation?
- How do different demographic compositions shape community engagement approaches?

Part II: Nine Dimensions of Event-Driven Resilience

The bi-coastal context adds new research questions to each dimension while maintaining the integrated framework.

Dimension 1: The Event

The event as organizing phenomenon—understanding how mega-events function as complex systems that temporarily transform urban environments and create unique operational requirements.

Bi-Coastal Research Questions

- How does the Olympics' 17-day continuous operation differ from discrete championship events in resilience requirements?
- What happens when events overlap with active disaster conditions (e.g., World Cup during fire season)?
- How do international events (FIFA, Olympics) create different governance complexity than national events (Super Bowl)?
- What cross-jurisdictional coordination models work when events span multiple cities (California FIFA venues)?

Dimension 2: Human Impact

Understanding how events affect the full spectrum of people touched—workers, attendees, residents, vulnerable populations—and ensuring that human wellbeing is centered in all decisions.

Bi-Coastal Research Questions

- How do events affect people experiencing homelessness, and what interventions support rather than displace them?
- What are the mental health impacts on communities still recovering from recent disasters (LA fires, Helene)?
- How do immigrant workers experience event employment, and what protections are needed?
- What accessibility innovations developed for Paralympics can transfer to other events and daily life?

Dimension 3: Community Innovation & Resilience

Building lasting community capacity that extends beyond the event—workforce pipelines, innovation ecosystems, organizational capability, and social infrastructure.

Bi-Coastal Research Questions

- How can Olympic legacy programming avoid the abandonment pattern seen in other host cities?
- What workforce pathways connect event employment to California's tech and entertainment industries?
- How do community land trusts and anti-displacement policies protect residents during event-driven development?
- What role do HBCUs (Spelman, Morehouse, Clark Atlanta) and HSIs (Cal State system) play in workforce pipelines?

Dimension 4: Life Safety

Protecting lives through public health systems, crowd safety science, medical services, behavioral health support, and harm prevention—before, during, and after events.

Bi-Coastal Research Questions

- How does extreme heat affect crowd safety differently in Los Angeles vs. Atlanta humidity?
- What happens when a wildfire smoke event coincides with outdoor Olympic competition?
- How should earthquake early warning systems integrate with crowd management at California venues?
- What behavioral health surge capacity is needed for events in communities with high baseline trauma?

Dimension 5: Critical Infrastructure

Understanding and protecting the interdependent systems—power, communications, water, cyber—that enable event operations and urban function.

Bi-Coastal Research Questions

- How do Public Safety Power Shutoffs (PSPS) affect event operations and what backup systems are needed?
- What water conservation requirements should apply to events during drought conditions?
- How can events accelerate grid modernization and renewable energy deployment?
- What cybersecurity threats are specific to international events with foreign actor interest?

Dimension 6: Venues

Stadium, arena, and event space operations—from access control and wayfinding to crowd flow and facility management.

Bi-Coastal Research Questions

- How do seismic requirements affect venue design and emergency egress in California?
- What temporary venue standards are needed for Olympic satellite locations?
- How should venues prepare for wildfire smoke infiltration during events?
- What cooling technologies protect attendees during extreme heat events?

Dimension 7: Emergency Preparedness

The planning, training, exercising, and capability-building that positions organizations to respond effectively when incidents occur.

Bi-Coastal Research Questions

- How do multi-hazard environments (earthquake + wildfire + event) require different planning approaches?
- What mutual aid agreements are needed when multiple events stress regional resources simultaneously?
- How should exercises incorporate climate scenarios that were historically unlikely but are now probable?
- What community emergency response team (CERT) models integrate with event preparedness?

Dimension 8: Emergency Response

Real-time incident management, multi-agency coordination, crisis communications, and decision-making under pressure.

Bi-Coastal Research Questions

- How do incident commanders make evacuation decisions when wildfires threaten event venues?
- What multilingual communication systems reach California's diverse population during emergencies?
- How do earthquake early warning systems (ShakeAlert) integrate with event operations?
- What AI decision-support tools enhance response without creating over-reliance or bias?

Dimension 9: Mass Transportation

Moving millions of people safely and efficiently—transit systems, traffic management, parking, pedestrian flow, and ensuring equitable access.

Bi-Coastal Research Questions

- How do car-dependent metros (LA, Atlanta) create equitable event access without transit infrastructure?
- What happens to regional traffic when Olympics venues are dispersed across Southern California?
- How can events accelerate permanent transit improvements rather than temporary solutions?
- What transportation innovations (autonomous vehicles, mobility hubs) can be piloted at events?

Part III: Bi-Coastal Partnership Structure

3.1 Academic Partners

ATLANTA HUB	CALIFORNIA HUB
Georgia Institute of Technology <i>AI/ML, infrastructure, engineering</i>	UCLA <i>Urban planning, Olympics research</i>
Spelman College <i>Community health, equity, HBCU pipeline</i>	USC <i>Public safety, disaster preparedness</i>
New York University <i>Urban policy, responsible AI (national)</i>	Stanford University <i>AI governance, climate resilience</i>
Kennesaw State University <i>Emergency management, public admin</i>	UC Berkeley <i>Seismic safety, infrastructure</i>
	Cal State System / CSU <i>HSI partnership, workforce dev</i>

3.2 Government Partners

- **California:** Cal OES, LA County OEM, City of LA Emergency Management, SF DEM, San Diego OES, CalFire, CHP
- **Georgia:** GEMA/HS, Atlanta Emergency Management, Fulton County EM, Atlanta Police, MARTA
- **Federal:** FEMA Region IX & IV, DHS/CISA, Secret Service (NSSE coordination)

3.3 Event & Venue Partners

- **California:** LA28 Olympic Committee, SoFi Stadium, Levi's Stadium, Rose Bowl, Crypto.com Arena, LA Sports Council
- **Georgia:** Atlanta Sports Council, Mercedes-Benz Stadium, State Farm Arena, AMB Group
- **Leagues:** NFL, FIFA, USOPC, MLS, NBA, WNBA

3.4 Community Partners

- **Atlanta:** Cascade UMC, Atlanta Neighborhood Planning Units, NAACP Atlanta, Atlanta BeltLine Partnership
- **Los Angeles:** LA Voice, Coalition for Responsible Community Development, East LA Community Corporation, LA Black Worker Center
- **Bay Area:** Urban Habitat, PolicyLink (national HQ), SPUR, Silicon Valley Rising

Part IV: Budget and Timeline

4.1 Expanded Budget Framework

The bi-coastal expansion significantly increases scope, requiring proportional budget increase:

Category	Annual	5-Year Total
Senior Personnel (PI, Regional Directors)	\$480,000	\$2,640,000
Research Staff (bi-coastal teams)	\$320,000	\$1,760,000
Graduate Research Assistants (8 per hub)	\$320,000	\$1,760,000
Community Co-Researcher Stipends	\$160,000	\$880,000
Equipment, Technology, Data	\$240,000	\$1,320,000
Travel, Fieldwork, Cross-Site Convenings	\$120,000	\$660,000
Publication, Dissemination, Translation	\$60,000	\$330,000
Indirect Costs (10%)	\$170,000	\$935,000
TOTAL	\$1,870,000	\$10,285,000

4.2 Timeline: The Convergence Window

Year	Atlanta Hub	California Hub
2026	FIFA World Cup event operations research	Super Bowl LX + FIFA World Cup research
2027	FIFA legacy assessment; SB29 pre-planning	Super Bowl LXI research; Olympics pre-planning
2028	Cross-site comparative analysis; SB29 prep intensive	LA 2028 OLYMPICS—17-day research intensive
2029	SUPER BOWL 2029—event operations research	Olympics legacy assessment; model dissemination
2030	Legacy assessment; sustainability planning	National model development; replication toolkit

Conclusion: The Bi-Coastal Living Learning Lab

Orchestrating Resilience v2.0 represents the most ambitious community-engaged research program ever designed around major sporting events. By spanning Atlanta and California's event corridors, this research creates:

- **Unmatched Scale:** Research across 2 FIFA World Cups, 3 Super Bowls, and the Olympics—the complete spectrum of major event types
- **Comparative Power:** Cross-regional analysis enabling insights that single-site studies cannot generate
- **Climate Integration:** First research program to systematically study how climate disasters compound major event challenges
- **Workforce Impact:** 800+ community members trained across both regions; 80+ graduate students supported
- **National Model:** Replicable framework for any city considering major event hosting

The communities that host these events—often those already bearing the burden of climate change, housing insecurity, and economic inequality—deserve to benefit from them. This research ensures they have the knowledge, the voice, and the power to shape how major events affect their lives.

As a veteran-owned, Black woman-led research organization with community roots in Atlanta and expanding partnerships across California, NOVATELabs is uniquely positioned to bridge these ecosystems. We bring the cultural competency to earn community trust, the academic rigor to produce credible research, and the operational understanding to make findings actionable.

The convergence window is open. The communities are ready. The research begins now.

– END OF FRAMEWORK v2.0 –